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QUESTION 1

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The Kepler space telescope, launched by NASA in 2009, detected exoplanets by monitoring the brightness of distant stars: when a planet crosses in front of its host star, it causes a small, repeating dip in brightness, an event called a transit. Kepler stared at a single patch of sky for years at a time. Its successor, TESS, uses the same transit method but sweeps across nearly the whole sky in short segments, concentrating on stars close enough for follow-up study.

According to the text, what distinguishes Kepler's observing strategy from that of TESS?

- A: Kepler measured dips in stellar brightness, while TESS photographs planets directly.
- B: Kepler concentrated on stars close enough for follow-up study, while TESS concentrates on more distant ones.
- C: Kepler observed a single region of sky for years, while TESS surveys nearly the whole sky in short segments.
- D: Kepler detected transits, while TESS analyzes the chemical makeup of planetary atmospheres.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The text says Kepler watched one patch of sky for years and TESS scans nearly the whole sky in short segments. Both use the same transit method, so A and D are out. B gives the right fact to the wrong telescope. Trick: when a passage compares two things, write 1 and 2 above the two names and tag every detail with 1 or 2. Most wrong answers are a true detail attached to the wrong name.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 2

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: In many traditional Japanese gardens, carefully raked gravel represents flowing water, and placed rocks stand for mountains or islands. These gardens are not meant to reproduce particular landscapes with literal accuracy; instead, they compress the feeling of nature into a small frame. Designers do borrow real features, such as the outline of a distant mountain, but they simplify them until only the suggestion remains.

According to the text, what is the relationship between traditional Japanese gardens and real landscapes?

- A: They borrow features from real landscapes but simplify them until only a suggestion remains.
- B: They reproduce particular mountains and rivers with careful geographic accuracy.
- C: They avoid real landscapes altogether and depend entirely on the designer's imagination.
- D: They copy real landscapes closely, differing from them only in scale.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The text says designers do borrow real features but simplify them. So the gardens neither copy exactly nor ignore reality. B and D copy too closely, and C ignores reality completely. Trick: "not literally" does not mean "not at all." When a passage rules out one extreme, the answer sits in the middle, never at the opposite extreme.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 3

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The axolotl, a salamander native to lakes near Mexico City, can regrow lost limbs, parts of its heart, and sections of its spinal cord, an ability biologists call epimorphic regeneration. It is unusual in a second way as well: it keeps its larval features, including its feathery external gills, for its entire life, a condition known as neoteny. Most salamanders shed these features during metamorphosis and move onto land, while the axolotl stays fully aquatic.

According to the text, which of the following best describes neoteny?

- A: The regrowth of lost limbs, heart tissue, and spinal cord.
- B: The loss of larval features at the close of the larval stage.
- C: The move from an aquatic habitat to a land habitat.
- D: The keeping of larval features, such as external gills, for the whole of an animal's life.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: The passage names three things: regeneration, neoteny, and metamorphosis. Neoteny is defined in the sentence about keeping larval features for life. A defines the wrong term, and B and C describe metamorphosis. Trick: when a passage defines more than one term, find your term in the passage first, then read only the words touching it.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 4

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Sociologist Anna Kessel studied four-day workweek trials at eleven Scandinavian firms. Employees working four days reported higher job satisfaction and lower burnout than employees at the same firms working five. Total output across the eleven firms held steady rather than falling, which Kessel credits to employees working more intensively during their reduced hours. Two firms did record small output gains, but Kessel calls these too slight to separate from ordinary seasonal variation.

According to the text, what happened to output at the firms in Kessel's study?

- A: Output rose across all eleven firms once employees adjusted to the schedule.
- B: Output held roughly steady, and the small gains at two firms were not counted as meaningful.
- C: Output rose at two firms, which Kessel offers as proof that shorter weeks raise productivity.
- D: Output fell slightly, though the decline was offset by gains in employee satisfaction.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: The text says output held steady rather than falling. Two firms gained a little, but Kessel calls that gain too small to separate from normal seasonal change. C uses a true fact and adds a conclusion the passage rejects. Trick: "did not fall" is not the same as "rose." If a passage calls a result too small to be meaningful, never pick the option that treats it as proof.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 5

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The Library of Ashurbanipal, assembled in the seventh century BCE at Nineveh, is among the oldest organized collections of texts. Excavators recovered roughly 30,000 clay tablets and tablet fragments inscribed in cuneiform. Scholars estimate that these fragments represent perhaps 1,200 distinct works, since a single long text could be spread across many tablets and a great many tablets survive only in pieces.

According to the text, why is the number of tablets so much larger than the number of distinct works?

- A: Many tablets were later copies made to replace works that had been damaged.
- B: The collection combined tablets brought to Nineveh from several separate libraries.
- C: Each work was recorded twice, once in cuneiform and once in a second script.
- D: One work could fill several tablets, and many tablets survive only as broken pieces.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: The final sentence gives the reason outright: one long text could spread across many tablets, and many tablets are fragments. So 30,000 tablets does not mean 30,000 works. Trick: when a question asks why two numbers differ, the reason is almost always in the same sentence as the smaller number. Read that sentence to the end.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 6

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Meteorologist Hana Otsuka explains that lake-effect snow forms when a cold air mass crosses water that is much warmer than the air above it. The air takes on moisture and heat, grows unstable, rises, and drops heavy snow on the downwind shore. The effect weakens sharply once a lake freezes over, because ice cuts off the supply of moisture. A long path across open water intensifies the snowfall, Otsuka adds, but it is not what starts the process.

According to the text, what happens to lake-effect snow after a lake freezes over?

A: It grows stronger, since the frozen surface chills the passing air more efficiently.

B: It shifts to the upwind shore, where the air is colder.

C: It weakens sharply, since ice cuts off the moisture the process depends on.

D: It continues at the same rate as long as the air's path across the lake stays long.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The passage says the effect weakens sharply once the lake freezes because ice cuts off moisture. D uses a real detail, the long path, but the passage says that detail only makes snow heavier and is not what starts the process. Trick: ask which factor the process cannot survive without, not which factor is merely mentioned.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 7

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The Rosetta Stone, found in Egypt in 1799, carries a single decree in three scripts: hieroglyphic, Demotic, and ancient Greek. Because scholars of the period could already read ancient Greek, the Greek version told them what the other two versions must say. Knowing the content in advance did not reveal how the hieroglyphic signs actually worked, and more than twenty years passed before Jean-Francois Champollion showed that those signs recorded sounds as well as ideas.

According to the text, how did the Greek text help scholars?

- A: It supplied details about the decree that the other two versions had left out.
- B: It told scholars what the hieroglyphic version said, but not how its signs worked.
- C: It showed that hieroglyphic signs recorded sounds rather than ideas.
- D: It let scholars read the hieroglyphic script within a few years of the stone's discovery.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: The Greek gave scholars the meaning of the decree, but the passage adds that this did not show how the signs worked. C is Champollion's later discovery, and D is ruled out by "more than twenty years." Trick: when a passage says a clue helped and then says "did not," the answer must carry both halves.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 8

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Behavioral ecologist Tomoko Igarashi found that adult vervet monkeys in East Africa produce acoustically distinct alarm calls for eagles, leopards, and snakes, and that each call triggers a different escape response. Infant vervets, by contrast, call in response to a much wider range of stimuli, including falling leaves and harmless birds. Igarashi reports that infants' calls become as selective as adults' only after roughly six months of watching how adults react.

According to the text, how do infant vervets differ from adult vervets?

A: Infants give alarm calls in response to many things that pose no threat.

B: Infants produce one call type rather than three distinct ones.

C: Infants react to alarm calls but do not produce any of their own.

D: Infants disregard adults' alarm calls until they are about six months old.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The passage says infants call at a much wider range of things, including falling leaves and harmless birds. D borrows the six month detail and flips its meaning, since infants learn by watching adults.

Trick: a number from the passage often reappears in a wrong answer with a new meaning attached. Check what the number was actually counting.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 9

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Economist Priya Nair reviewed randomized trials of microfinance in six countries. Recipients of microloans did put money into small business activity, and their business revenues rose modestly. Household income and consumption, however, were not significantly different from those of control households that received no loans. Nair points out that recipients' incomes were higher than they had been before the loans, but that control households' incomes had risen as well, and she argues that the loans are simply too small to create the scale a business needs to grow.

According to the text, what did the comparison with control households show?

- A: Control households' incomes fell while recipient households' incomes held steady.
- B: Recipient households' business revenues were no different from those of control households.
- C: Recipient households' incomes rose, but no more than control households' incomes rose.
- D: Recipient households showed no economic change of any kind after receiving loans.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Recipients' incomes went up and control incomes went up too, so the gap between groups was not significant. D is too strong, because business revenue did rise. Trick: "no significant difference" means both groups moved the same way, not that nothing happened. Always ask what a group is being compared to.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 10

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Archaeologist Liam Gallagher argues that the alignment of Neolithic stone circles in northern Scotland was set by the shape of the surrounding land rather than by astronomy, noting that gaps between standing stones at several sites line up with mountain passes and river valleys. Gallagher accepts that a handful of circles in Orkney do align with the midwinter sunrise, but he treats these as exceptions. It is his colleague Ruth Bevan who maintains that the astronomical alignments are the rule and the landscape alignments the coincidence.

According to the text, what does Gallagher claim about the circles that align with the midwinter sunrise?

A: He argues that they are the rule and that landscape alignments are coincidental.

B: He denies that any such alignments exist.

C: He credits Bevan with identifying them in Orkney before he did.

D: He accepts that they exist but treats them as exceptions to his explanation.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: The passage says Gallagher accepts the Orkney alignments and calls them exceptions. A is Bevan's position, not Gallagher's. Trick: when two names appear, draw a line from each name to that person's claim before reading the options. Wrong answers swap the two views.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 11

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Marine biologist Lena Kowalski tagged manta rays in the Coral Triangle. Her tracking data showed that the rays adjusted their swimming depth and route toward patches of dense zooplankton rather than filtering water at random, and that individuals returned to the same productive sites at consistent times of day. Kowalski suggests that this timing implies some form of spatial and temporal memory, though she notes that the tags cannot separate memory from a simple response to daily shifts in current.

According to the text, which of the following did Kowalski's tracking data establish?

- A: That the rays returned to the same feeding sites at consistent times of day.
- B: That the rays possess spatial and temporal memory.
- C: That the rays follow daily shifts in current rather than relying on memory.
- D: That the rays feed on a wider range of prey than zooplankton.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The data showed where the rays went and when. Memory is what Kowalski thinks the data might imply, and she says the tags cannot prove it. Trick: separate what was measured from what the researcher thinks it means. Words like "suggests," "implies," and "may" mark an idea, not a finding.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 12

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Political scientist Mei Tanaka describes what she calls policy feedback loops in public healthcare. In Tanaka's account the sequence runs in one direction: enacting a universal healthcare program creates a large group of beneficiaries, that group then develops a shared interest in protecting the program, and the resulting political pressure makes repeal costly for any government that attempts it. Tanaka stresses that this constituency does not exist beforehand, since the policy manufactures its own defenders.

According to the text, what does Tanaka say about the constituency that defends universal healthcare?

A: It forms first and then pressures governments into enacting the policy.

B: It is created by the policy itself and afterward resists repeal.

C: It consists mainly of program administrators rather than patients.

D: It weakens over time as the cost of the program grows.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: The passage says the constituency does not exist beforehand and that the policy makes its own defenders. A reverses the order. Trick: when a passage lays out a sequence, number the steps 1, 2, 3 in the margin. Reversed order is the most common wrong answer on cause and effect questions.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 13

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Architect Rosa Martin's Canopy Pavilion in Valencia has a roof of interlocking ceramic tiles arranged in a pattern modeled on pinecone scales. Martin angled the tiles in order to channel rainwater into a central basin that irrigates the surrounding gardens. She has noted that the overlapping arrangement also happens to shade the walls and lower indoor temperatures by several degrees, an outcome she did not plan for but now mentions whenever she explains the design.

According to the text, what was Martin's purpose in angling the tiles?

- A: To shade the walls and lower indoor temperatures.
- B: To imitate the appearance of pinecone scales as closely as possible.
- C: To channel rainwater into a basin used to irrigate the gardens.
- D: To reduce the load the roof places on the pavilion's supports.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The passage says Martin angled the tiles in order to channel rainwater. The cooling is something she did not plan for, so it is a side effect. Trick: "in order to" marks a purpose, while "also happens to" marks a bonus. The question asked for purpose, so take the "in order to" one.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 14

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Cognitive psychologist Elena Rossi had participants solve anagrams either in silence or while instrumental music played at moderate volume. On anagrams of moderate difficulty the music group solved puzzles faster. On the hardest anagrams the two groups performed the same. On the easiest anagrams the silence group was slightly faster, a difference Rossi attributes to the music briefly pulling attention away from a task that demands almost none. She concludes that music helps only inside a narrow band of difficulty.

According to the text, on which anagrams did the silence group outperform the music group?

- A: On the easiest anagrams, where Rossi says the music briefly pulled attention from a task needing little of it.
- B: On the moderately difficult anagrams, where the gap between the groups was widest.
- C: On the hardest anagrams, where the music group's advantage disappeared.
- D: On none of them, since the music group was faster at every level of difficulty.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Music won at moderate, the groups tied at hardest, and silence won at easiest. The question asks where silence won. Trick: when a passage reports results at three levels, write a quick three line list before reading the options. Most wrong answers move a real result to the wrong level.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 15

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Historian Youssef El-Amine has examined coffeehouses in seventeenth-century Ottoman intellectual life. He does not dispute that they were places of leisure, where patrons played games and passed the afternoon. His claim is that leisure was not all they were: the same rooms hosted poets circulating manuscripts, scholars arguing over philosophy, and administrators discussing affairs of state. El-Amine calls the coffeehouse an institution that historians have counted as social and have therefore failed to count as intellectual.

According to the text, what is El-Amine's claim about the leisure function of coffeehouses?

- A: He argues that the leisure function was invented by later historians.
- B: He accepts the leisure function but argues that it was not the whole of what coffeehouses were.
- C: He argues that leisure activities gradually crowded out intellectual ones.
- D: He argues that leisure and intellectual activity took place in separate establishments.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: El-Amine does not dispute the leisure side, and his point is that leisure was not all coffeehouses were. He is adding to the old view rather than deleting it. Trick: "not merely" and "not all it was" mean the writer is adding something. Reject any option that says the old idea was false.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 16

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Entomologist Clara Voss found that a Costa Rican parasitoid wasp lays its eggs inside the larvae of a single beetle species. The hatched wasp larvae feed first on fat stores and other tissue the beetle does not need to survive, leaving the vital organs intact so that the host stays alive and its tissue stays fresh. Voss notes that the parasitized beetle keeps eating and even grows during this stage. Only when the wasp larvae are nearly ready to pupate do they consume the remaining tissue, killing the host.

According to the text, what do the wasp larvae eat during the early stage of their development?

- A: The remaining tissue of the host, which kills it.
- B: The beetle's vital organs, starting with the largest.
- C: Plant material that the parasitized beetle continues to eat.
- D: Fat stores and other tissue the beetle does not need in order to stay alive.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: The passage says the larvae feed first on fat stores and non-essential tissue. A is what they do at the very end. Trick: for questions containing "early," "first," or "initially," find the passage word that matches the time and read only from that point.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 17

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Psycholinguist Omar Said asked Spanish and German speakers to describe a key, a noun that is feminine in Spanish and masculine in German. Spanish speakers reached for adjectives such as delicate and elegant, while German speakers chose sturdy and heavy. Said reports that the pattern vanished when the same participants completed the task in English, and he takes this as evidence that the effect depends on the language a speaker is using at the moment rather than on a fixed difference in how the two groups see objects.

According to the text, what happened when participants performed the task in English?

- A: German speakers went on using adjectives tied to masculine nouns.
- B: Both groups described the key in more abstract terms than before.
- C: The difference between the two groups' adjective choices vanished.
- D: Spanish speakers adopted the adjectives the German speakers had used.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The passage states directly that the pattern vanished in English, which is why Said says the effect depends on the language in use at the time. Trick: when a passage adds a second condition, that condition is usually what the question is about. Find the sentence where something changes.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 18

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Engineer Fatima al-Rashid's portable purifier uses solar-powered ultraviolet light to neutralize waterborne pathogens, with no chemicals and no replaceable filters. In trials in rural Senegal it purified about 20 liters an hour, enough for a family of four. Al-Rashid notes two constraints. The ultraviolet light neutralizes microbes but does nothing to remove dissolved metals or suspended sediment, so cloudy water has to be strained beforehand. Output also falls on overcast days, which limits the device in regions with long cloudy seasons.

According to the text, why must cloudy water be strained before treatment?

A: Because ultraviolet light neutralizes microbes but does not remove sediment or dissolved metals.

B: Because sediment reduces the amount of sunlight the device can collect.

C: Because the device's filters clog when sediment is present.

D: Because straining raises the device's output above 20 liters per hour.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The passage lists two separate problems. Straining is needed because ultraviolet light does not remove sediment or dissolved metals. Cloud cover is the other problem, and C is impossible because the device has no filters. Trick: when a passage names two limits, label them 1 and 2, then match the question to the right one.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 19

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Neuroscientist Arjun Mehta scanned expert and novice chess players as they evaluated board positions. Experts showed heightened activity in the fusiform face area, a region normally linked to face recognition, while novices showed none. Mehta is careful about what this shows. He proposes that expertise recruits the region for holistic pattern recognition of a kind similar to face perception, and he notes that the experts' own face recognition was unimpaired, so the region appears to be extended to a second use rather than taken over.

According to the text, what does Mehta say about the experts' ability to recognize faces?

- A: It declined as the fusiform face area was recruited for chess.
- B: It was unaffected, which is why Mehta describes the region as extended to a second use.
- C: It improved as their chess expertise grew.
- D: It was not measured, so Mehta draws no conclusion about it.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: The passage says the experts' face recognition was unimpaired, and that is why Mehta calls the region extended rather than taken over. D is tempting but wrong, since the passage does report it. Trick: before choosing "not mentioned," hunt for the exact words from the question inside the passage.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 20

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Literary critic Nkechi Okafor observes that the narrator of Chinua Achebe's *Things Fall Apart* avoids elaborate metaphor and withholds explicit judgment on the events described. Okafor rejects the reading that this restraint signals detachment from or disapproval of those events. In her view the restraint is an act of imitation: Igbo communal narrators traditionally present events and leave listeners to draw the moral, and Achebe's narrator reproduces that expectation instead of expressing an attitude of his own.

According to the text, which reading of the narrator's restraint does Okafor reject?

- A: That the restraint reproduces the practice of Igbo communal narrators.
- B: That the restraint leaves moral conclusions to the listener or reader.
- C: That the restraint expresses the narrator's detachment from or disapproval of the events.
- D: That the restraint involves avoiding elaborate metaphor.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The passage says Okafor rejects the reading that restraint signals detachment or disapproval. A and B are what she actually believes. Trick: when the question asks what someone rejects, circle the word "rejects" in the passage and take only the words right after it.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 21

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Geochemist Hiro Watanabe questions whether the iridium concentrated in the clay layer at the Cretaceous-Paleogene boundary came only from the Chicxulub asteroid impact, as the standard model holds. Watanabe accepts that the impact occurred and that it delivered iridium. His argument is that the Deccan Traps eruptions, which overlapped the same interval, also vent iridium, and that the layer may therefore record both sources. He adds that he does not claim to know the proportion contributed by each.

According to the text, what does Watanabe accept about the standard model?

- A: That the Chicxulub impact was the sole source of the iridium.
- B: That the Deccan Traps eruptions supplied most of the iridium.
- C: That the share contributed by each source is now known.
- D: That the Chicxulub impact occurred and did deliver iridium to the boundary layer.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Watanabe accepts that the impact happened and delivered iridium. The only word he disputes is "only." B and C go past what he says, since he states he does not know the proportions. Trick: challenging one word in a claim is not rejecting the whole claim. Find the exact word under dispute and keep everything else.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 22

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Economist Adaora Ibe compared sub-Saharan districts within 20 kilometers of a colonial railroad with otherwise similar districts farther away. Near-railroad districts had, on average, 15 percent higher per capita income in 2015. Ibe shows that this average hides a split. Landowners and merchants in those districts earned substantially more than their counterparts elsewhere, while subsistence farmers in near-railroad districts earned about the same as subsistence farmers far from the line.

According to the text, how did subsistence farmers near railroads compare with subsistence farmers far from railroads?

- A: They earned roughly the same amount.
- B: They earned about 15 percent more.
- C: They earned more, though less than landowners and merchants gained.
- D: They earned less, because land near the line was bought up by merchants.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The passage says subsistence farmers near the line earned about the same as those far from it. The 15 percent belongs to the district average, not to the farmers. Trick: an average for a whole group does not apply to every group inside it. Check whether the passage gives a separate figure for the exact group named in the question.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 23

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Psychologist Bianca Torres randomly assigned participants to watch either a nature documentary or a control video on interior design, then measured their willingness to pay higher taxes for conservation. Among participants who had reported low prior engagement with environmental issues, documentary viewers were far more willing to pay than control viewers. Among participants already highly engaged, documentary viewers and control viewers scored the same, and both scored near the top of the scale. Torres reads this second result as a ceiling effect rather than as evidence that the documentary failed.

According to the text, why does Torres describe the result for highly engaged participants as a ceiling effect?

A: Because their scores dropped after they watched the documentary.

B: Because they already scored near the top of the scale, leaving little room to rise.

C: Because both the documentary and control groups scored near the bottom of the scale.

D: Because they were removed from the analysis once their prior engagement was known.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Both groups of highly engaged participants scored near the top of the scale, and a score already at the top cannot climb much higher. Trick: when a passage names a term and puts a detail right beside it, that detail is the definition. Match the two and ignore outside knowledge.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 24

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Biochemist Soren Lindgren studied deep-sea bacteria that produce piezolipids, membrane lipids that stay flexible at pressures which would stiffen ordinary bacterial membranes and kill the cell. To test whether these lipids were enough on their own, Lindgren engineered a surface-dwelling species to manufacture them. The modified bacteria survived to 400 atmospheres, while unmodified bacteria of the same species died above 100. Lindgren notes that the modified cells still grew more slowly at depth than true deep-sea species do, indicating that piezolipids account for survival but not for full adaptation.

According to the text, what did the modified bacteria fail to match?

- A: The pressure tolerance of unmodified bacteria of the same species.
- B: The membrane flexibility that piezolipids provide.
- C: The growth rate of true deep-sea species at depth.
- D: The ability of deep-sea species to produce piezolipids at all.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The last sentence says the modified cells grew more slowly at depth than true deep-sea species. They did gain pressure tolerance and they did make piezolipids. Trick: when a passage says something explains one thing "but not" another, the words sitting after "but not" are usually the answer.

END QUESTION

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QUESTION 25

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Art historian Rina Chakraborty argues that Chola artisans chose alloy compositions in order to control the patinas their bronzes would develop over centuries, where earlier scholars treated patina color as an accident of aging. Her case rests on a correlation: sculptures of benevolent deities are consistently copper-rich, which weathers green, while sculptures of fierce deities are tin-rich, which weathers brown. She grants that no Chola text describes the practice and that a correlation cannot by itself prove intent, but maintains that the pattern is far too regular to be chance.

According to the text, what does Chakraborty concede about her argument?

- A: That the correlation between alloy and deity type is weaker than she once believed.
- B: That earlier scholars were right to treat patina color as accidental.
- C: That copper-rich and tin-rich bronzes weather to the same color over long periods.
- D: That no Chola text describes the practice and that correlation alone cannot prove intent.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: She grants two things: no Chola text records the practice, and correlation by itself cannot prove intent. She still insists the pattern is too regular to be chance, so B is wrong. Trick: find the word "concedes," "grants," or "admits" and take only what follows it. A concession is never a surrender of the main claim.

END QUESTION